

08

The Four Pawns Attack

Undermine maximum space before it becomes a permanent bind



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

Meet White's broad center with timely flank and central breaks instead of passive defense.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 043 | PAGE 4

Decode: The c5 and e6 challenge

Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

LESSON 044 | PAGE 8

Play: The c5 and e6 challenge

Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

LESSON 045 | PAGE 12

Decode: The e5 advance

A pawn advance is strongest before contact and weakest immediately after it creates targets.

LESSON 046 | PAGE 16

Play: The e5 advance

A pawn advance is strongest before contact and weakest immediately after it creates targets.

LESSON 047 | PAGE 20

Decode: The Na6 alternative

Name the destination before choosing the detour.

LESSON 048 | PAGE 24

Play: The Na6 alternative

Name the destination before choosing the detour.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

Meet White's broad center with timely flank and central breaks instead of passive defense.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The c5 and e6 challenge

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

White has built maximum space, so Black attacks the chain before development makes it untouchable.

DECISION RULE

Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Pressure e4 and d5, use the e-file, and finish development with tempo.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White may push e5, support the center, or expand on the kingside.

MEMORY RULE | Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White has built maximum space, so Black attacks the chain before development makes it untouchable.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Pressure e4 and d5, use the e-file, and finish development with tempo.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White may push e5, support the center, or expand on the kingside.

FAILURE MODE

Waiting allows White to complete development behind a space advantage.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

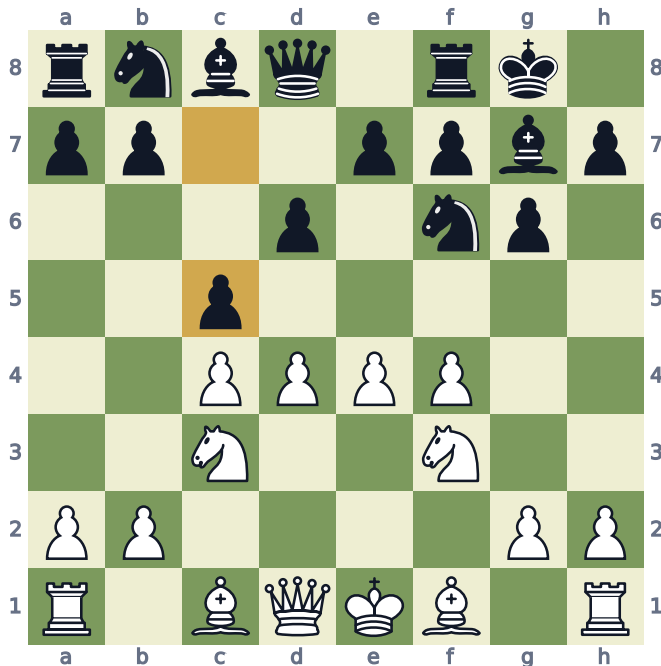
RULE | Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 c5 7. d5 e6 8. Be2 exd5 9. cxd5



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- f4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- c5: Black attacks the center from the flank and invites a Benoni-like transformation.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White has built maximum space, so Black attacks the chain before development makes it untouchable.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous. White's resistance is: White may push e5, support the center, or expand on the kingside. The line fails as a template when: Waiting allows White to complete development behind a space advantage.

STORE THIS | Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. White has built maximum space, so Black attacks the chain before development makes it untouchable. 2. Pressure e4 and d5, use the e-file, and finish development with tempo. 3. White may push e5, support the center, or expand on the kingside. 4. Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous. 5. Waiting allows White to complete development behind a space advantage.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 c5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The c5 and e6 challenge



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White has built maximum space, so Black attacks the chain before development makes it untouchable.

DECISION RULE

Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Pressure e4 and d5, use the e-file, and finish development with tempo.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White has built maximum space, so Black attacks the chain before development makes it untouchable.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Pressure e4 and d5, use the e-file, and finish development with tempo.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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FAILURE MODE

Waiting allows White to complete development behind a space advantage.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

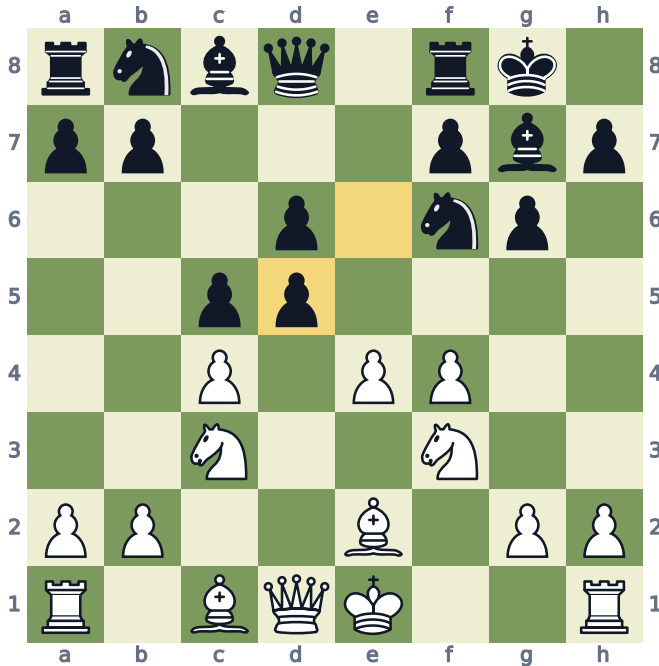
RULE | Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 c5 7. d5 e6 8. Be2 exd5 9. cxd5



- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- c5: Black attacks the center from the flank and invites a Benoni-like transformation.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- exd5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White has built maximum space, so Black attacks the chain before development makes it untouchable.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous. White's resistance is: White may push e5, support the center, or expand on the kingside. The line fails as a template when: Waiting allows White to complete development behind a space advantage.

STORE THIS | Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

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ANSWER KEY

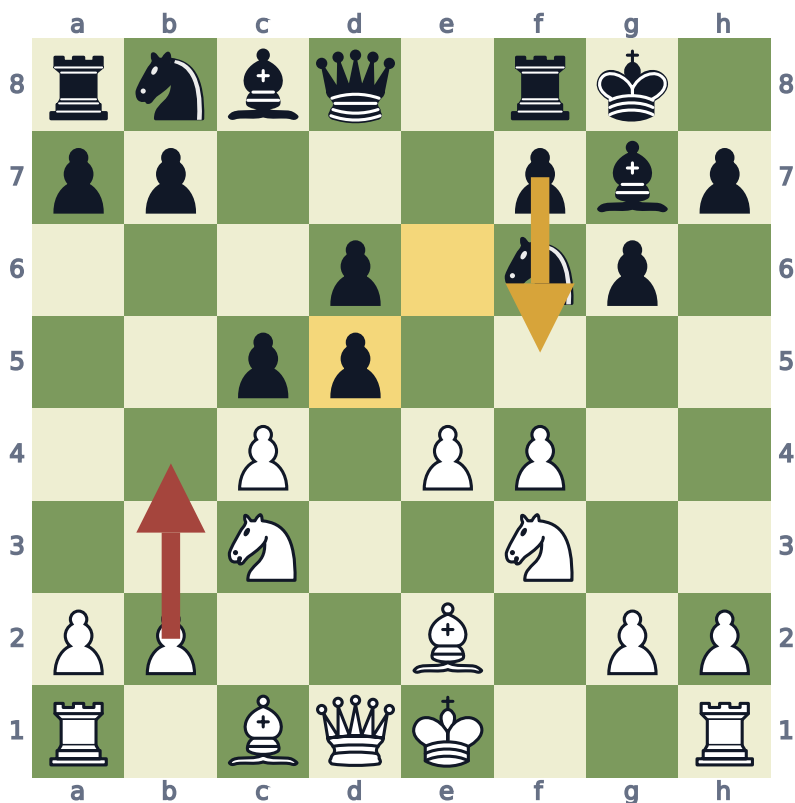
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Nf3 c5 7. d5 e6 8. Be2 exd5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The e5 advance



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White's e5 push gains space but also creates tactical contact with the f6-knight and e-file.

DECISION RULE

Calculate every forcing response to e5 before choosing a routine developing move.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Attack e5, use ...Ng4 or ...Nfd7 routes, and exploit the exposed central king.

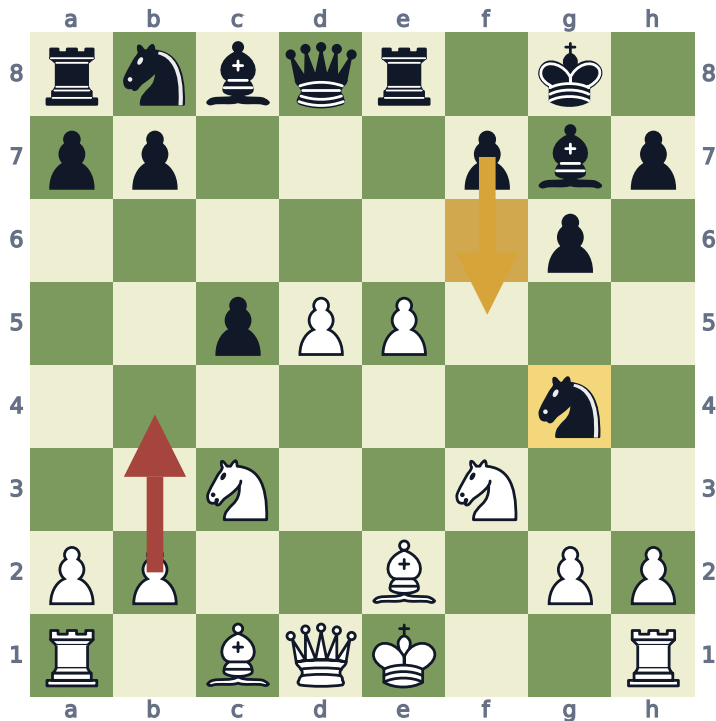
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White wants to drive the knight and maintain the pawn wedge.

MEMORY RULE | A pawn advance is strongest before contact and weakest immediately after it creates targets.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White's e5 push gains space but also creates tactical contact with the f6-knight and e-file.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Attack e5, use ...Ng4 or ...Nfd7 routes, and exploit the exposed central king.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White wants to drive the knight and maintain the pawn wedge.

FAILURE MODE

If Black retreats passively, the center can become a stable attacking platform.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Calculate every forcing response to e5 before choosing a routine developing move. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

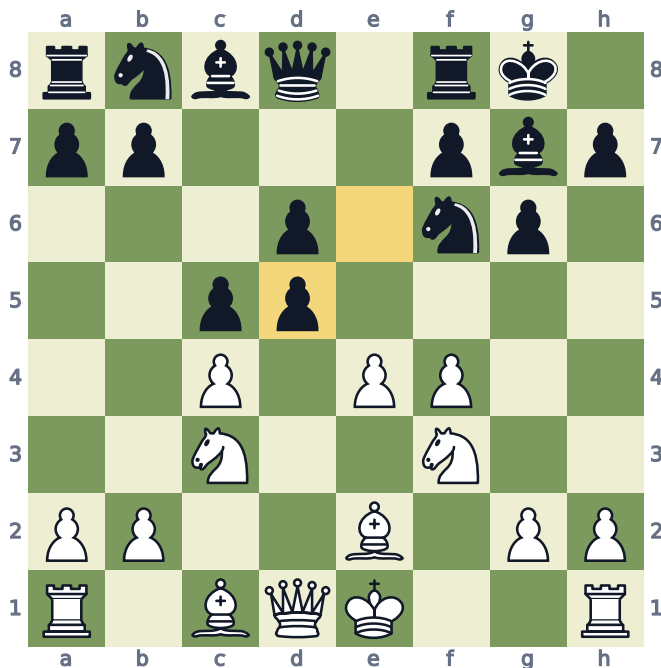
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 c5 7. d5 e6 8. Be2 exd5 9. cxd5 Re8 10. e5 dxe5 11. fxe5 Ng4



- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
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Retrieval and self-coaching

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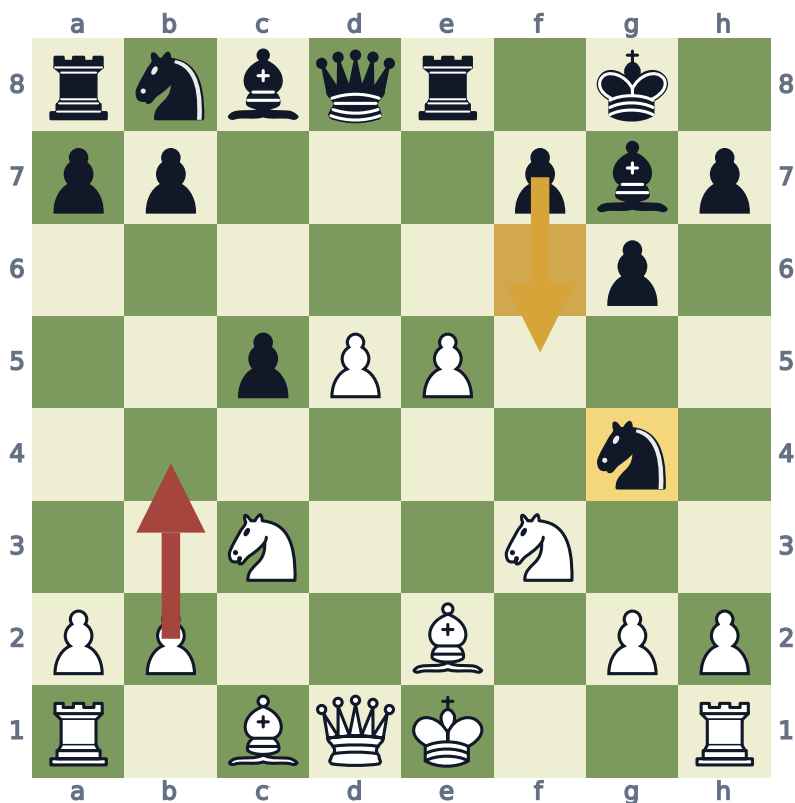
1. White's e5 push gains space but also creates tactical contact with the f6-knight and e-file. 2. Attack e5, use ...Ng4 or ...Nfd7 routes, and exploit the exposed central king. 3. White wants to drive the knight and maintain the pawn wedge. 4. Calculate every forcing response to e5 before choosing a routine developing move. 5. If Black retreats passively, the center can become a stable attacking platform.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Nf3 c5 7. d5 e6 8. Be2 exd5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The e5 advance



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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

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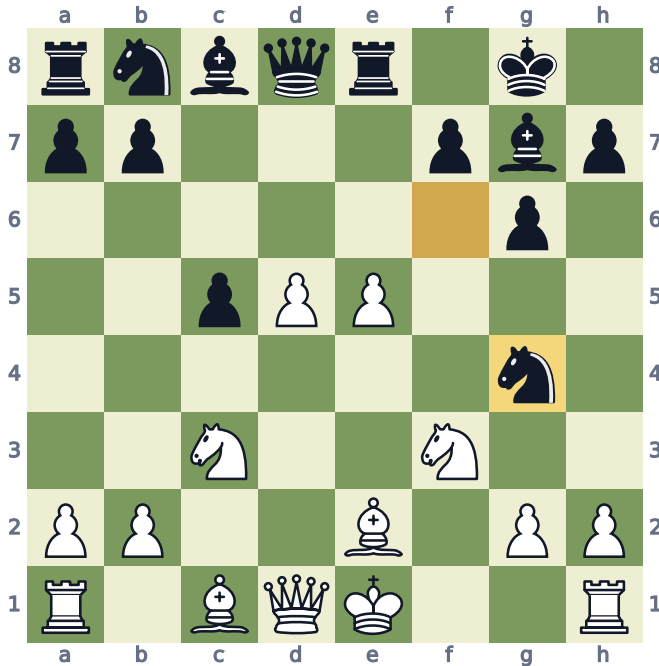
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Move-by-move meaning

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- cxd5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Re8: Black places a rook on a line expected to open or uses it to support a central transformation.
- e5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- dxe5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- fxe5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Ng4: Black reroutes a knight toward g4; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

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ANSWER KEY

1. White's e5 push gains space but also creates tactical contact with the f6-knight and e-file. 2. Attack e5, use ...Ng4 or ...Nfd7 routes, and exploit the exposed central king. 3. White wants to drive the knight and maintain the pawn wedge. 4. Calculate every forcing response to e5 before choosing a routine developing move. 5. If Black retreats passively, the center can become a stable attacking platform.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. cxd5 Re8 10. e5 dxe5 11. fxe5 Ng4

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The Na6 alternative

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

...Na6 develops away from the e-pawn's advance and prepares pressure on e4 or c5.

DECISION RULE

Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use the knight actively on c5 and challenge the center with ...c6 or ...c5.

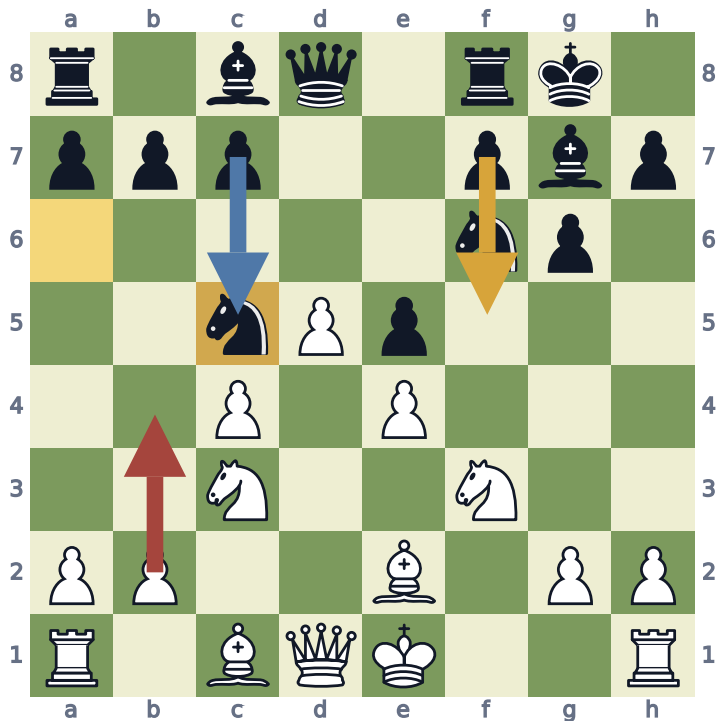
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White closes with d5 and tries to preserve space while completing development.

MEMORY RULE | Name the destination before choosing the detour.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...Na6 develops away from the e-pawn's advance and prepares pressure on e4 or c5.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Use the knight actively on c5 and challenge the center with ...c6 or ...c5.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White closes with d5 and tries to preserve space while completing development.

FAILURE MODE

A knight on the rim is justified only by a concrete route.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

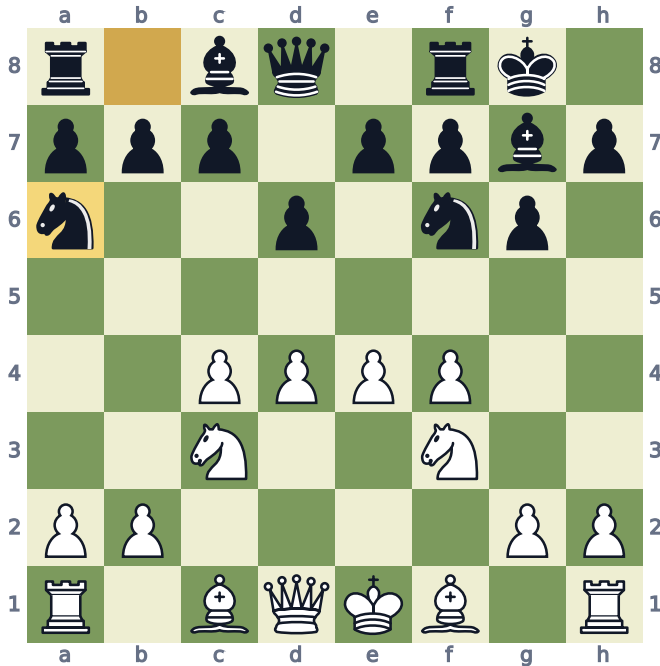
RULE | Name the destination before choosing the detour.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 Na6 7. Be2 e5 8. fxe5 dxe5 9. d5 Nc5



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- f4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- Na6: Black reroutes a knight toward a6; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...Na6 develops away from the e-pawn's advance and prepares pressure on e4 or c5.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight. White's resistance is: White closes with d5 and tries to preserve space while completing development. The line fails as a template when: A knight on the rim is justified only by a concrete route.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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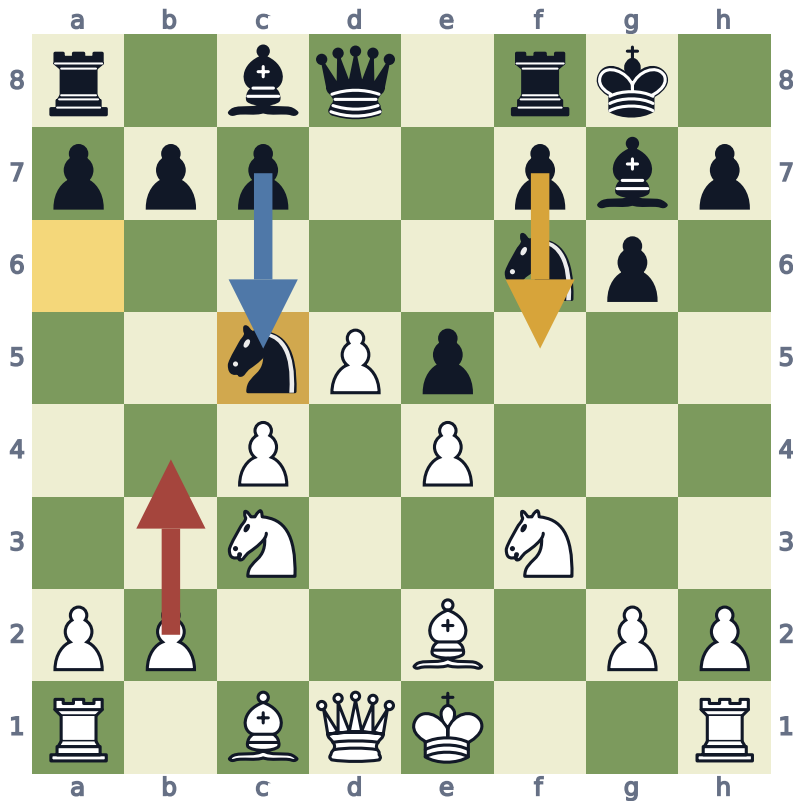
1. ...Na6 develops away from the e-pawn's advance and prepares pressure on e4 or c5. 2. Use the knight actively on c5 and challenge the center with ...c6 or ...c5. 3. White closes with d5 and tries to preserve space while completing development. 4. Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight. 5. A knight on the rim is justified only by a concrete route.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 Na6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The Na6 alternative



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...Na6 develops away from the e-pawn's advance and prepares pressure on e4 or c5.

DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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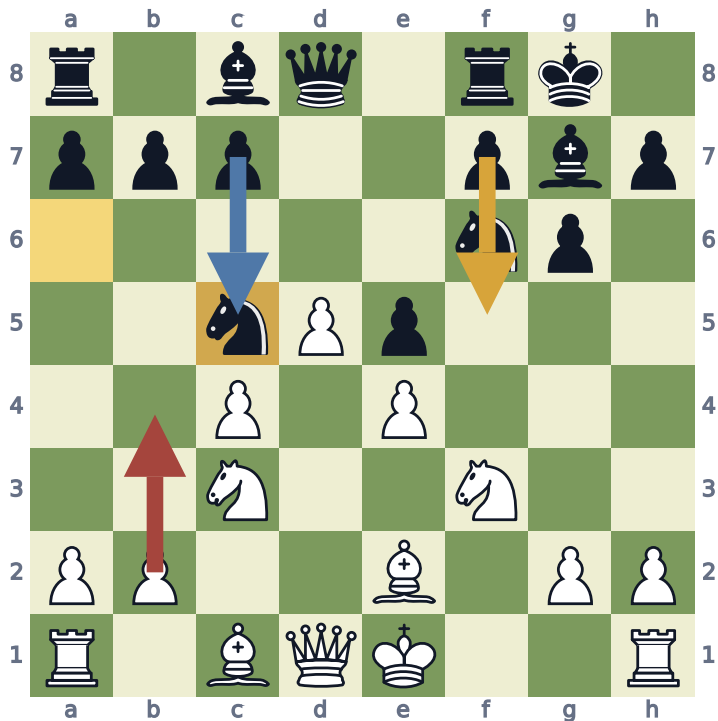
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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White closes with d5 and tries to preserve space while completing development.

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Ask: Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

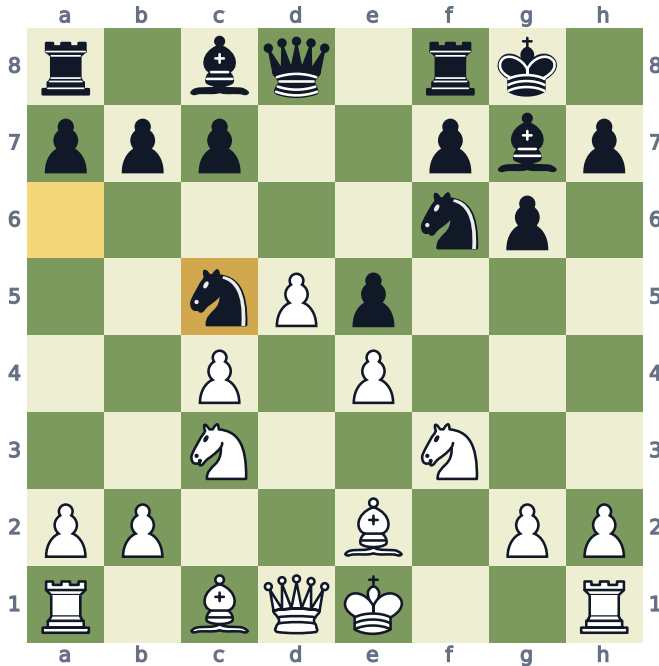
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 Na6 7. Be2 e5 8. fxe5 dxe5 9. d5 Nc5



- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- fxe5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- dxe5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Nc5: Black reroutes a knight toward c5; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...Na6 develops away from the e-pawn's advance and prepares pressure on e4 or c5.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight. White's resistance is: White closes with d5 and tries to preserve space while completing development. The line fails as a template when: A knight on the rim is justified only by a concrete route.

STORE THIS | Name the destination before choosing the detour.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. ...Na6 develops away from the e-pawn's advance and prepares pressure on e4 or c5. 2. Use the knight actively on c5 and challenge the center with ...c6 or ...c5. 3. White closes with d5 and tries to preserve space while completing development. 4. Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight. 5. A knight on the rim is justified only by a concrete route.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Be2 e5 8. fxe5 dxe5 9. d5 Nc5

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 043 Decode: The c5 and e6 challenge

Prompt: Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous.

Recall: Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

LESSON 044 Play: The c5 and e6 challenge

Prompt: Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous.

Recall: Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

LESSON 045 Decode: The e5 advance

Prompt: Calculate every forcing response to e5 before choosing a routine developing move.

Recall: A pawn advance is strongest before contact and weakest immediately after it creates targets.

LESSON 046 Play: The e5 advance

Prompt: Calculate every forcing response to e5 before choosing a routine developing move.

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LESSON 047 Decode: The Na6 alternative

Prompt: Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight.

Recall: Name the destination before choosing the detour.

LESSON 048 Play: The Na6 alternative

Prompt: Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight.

Recall: Name the destination before choosing the detour.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

The c5 and e6 challenge

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 c5 7. d5 e6 8. Be2 exd5 9. cxd5

Decision: Calculate the central capture order and whether e4-e5 is dangerous.

Memory: Against four pawns, counterattack the center before admiring it.

CARD 2

The e5 advance

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 c5 7. d5 e6 8. Be2 exd5 9. cxd5 Re8 10. e5 dxe5 11. fxe5 Ng4

Decision: Calculate every forcing response to e5 before choosing a routine developing move.

Memory: A pawn advance is strongest before contact and weakest immediately after it creates targets.

CARD 3

The Na6 alternative

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. f4 O-O 6. Nf3 Na6 7. Be2 e5 8. fxe5 dxe5 9. d5 Nc5

Decision: Judge whether the c5 outpost is stable and whether White can b4 the knight.

Memory: Name the destination before choosing the detour.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
043 Decode: The c5 and e6 challenge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
044 Play: The c5 and e6 challenge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
045 Decode: The e5 advance	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
046 Play: The e5 advance	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
047 Decode: The Na6 alternative	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
048 Play: The Na6 alternative	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.